

What Sift does

Install

Three words

The rail

SCREENS

Review 1

Duplicates 2

Log 3

Filed 4

To re-source 5

Trash 6

Rekordbox 7

USB drive 8

Settings 9

NEXT

The keyboard

Your guarantees

The limits

What's new

If something goes wrong

Sift prepares a DJ library.

It spots fake lossless files, finds duplicates, files every track in the right format and the right place, then sends the library to Rekordbox and onto a USB drive.

One rule governs everything else: **moving a track means converting it and filing it in the same gesture**. Sift deletes nothing unless you ask for it, and it never modifies a folder it watches.

This manual follows the order of a working session: install, learn three words, then walk the left rail from top to bottom.

Install

One file to download, depending on your machine. Everything else on the release page serves the automatic updater and does not install: `.app.tar.gz`, `.msi`, the `.sig` files, `latest.json`. The `.app.tar.gz` is the classic trap: it weighs more than the `.dmg`, so it looks like the right one.

Your machine	The file to take
Windows	<code>Sift_<version>_x64-setup.exe</code>
Mac with Apple silicon (M1 and later)	<code>Sift_<version>_aarch64.dmg</code>
Intel Mac	<code>Sift_<version>_x64.dmg</code>

Every version is on [the releases page](#). The installers are not signed, for want of an Apple or Microsoft certificate: your system shows a warning on first launch, once.

On Windows

SmartScreen announces “Windows protected your PC”. Click **More info**, then **Run anyway**.

On Mac

Open the `.dmg`, drag Sift into Applications, then depending on the message:

- “unidentified developer”: open **System Settings > Privacy & Security**, scroll down to the message about Sift and click **Open Anyway**;
- “Sift is damaged and can't be opened”: this message offers no button. Open Terminal and type the command below. The `-r` is required — a Mac application is a folder.

```
xattr -dr com.apple.quarantine /Applications/Sift.app
```

If the message persists: `codesign --force --deep --sign - /Applications/Sift.app`

Later versions install themselves, from inside the application.

What Sift does

Install

Three words

The rail

SCREENS

Review 1

Duplicates 2

Log 3

Filed 4

To re-source 5

Trash 6

Rekordbox 7

USB drive 8

Settings 9

NEXT

The keyboard

Your guarantees

The limits

What's new

If something goes wrong

Three words to know

Fake lossless. A FLAC, WAV or AIFF file built from an MP3, an AAC or an Opus. The label says lossless, but the sound has already been compressed, and that quality is not coming back. These files are sold, they circulate, and the difference is not always audible. This is what Sift looks for.

Verdict. What Sift concludes about a file, in one word:

Verdict	What it means
GENUINE	Nothing in the signal contradicts a real lossless file.
FAKE	The compression is measurable. The file is set aside to be bought again elsewhere, it is not deleted.
TO CHECK	Something unusual, without proof. Sift flags it and leaves you to decide, spectrogram in hand.

Set aside. Taking a file out of the flow without deleting it: it goes to **To re-source**, to buy again or find elsewhere. The **Trash** receives what you throw away from Filed, Duplicates or To re-source. Nothing is erased until you empty the Trash yourself.

The interface language

Sift speaks English and French. You choose in **Settings > Appearance > Language**, where **Auto** follows your system; changing the language reloads the window. In French, the three verdicts read **VRAI**, **FAUX** and **À VÉRIFIER**.

LOSSLESS, **DUPLICATE**, **MATCH**, **XML**, **kbps**, **kHz**, **MP3**, **AIFF**, **WAV** are the same in both languages, because that is the form they take everywhere else: in Rekordbox, in the stores, on the forums.

The rail, top to bottom

The left column has two parts. At the top, your **sources**: the folders Sift watches, each with its color, its number of pending files and its state. Clicking a source narrows the Review list to its files. A folder with no recognized audio file is marked “0 audio”.

Below, nine **screens**, in the order of a working session. **Ctrl+1** through **Ctrl+9** go straight to them (⌘ on Mac), and **Ctrl+B** collapses the column.

Review **Ctrl+1**

Decide, one track at a time. This is where the work happens.

Duplicates **Ctrl+2**

Every copy of the same track, compared: choose which to keep.

Log **Ctrl+3**

Everything Sift has done, and the way to undo it.

Filed **Ctrl+4**

Your library, what is in its place.

What Sift does

Install

Three words

The rail

SCREENS

Review 1

Duplicates 2

Log 3

Filed 4

To re-source 5

Trash 6

Rekordbox 7

USB drive 8

Settings 9

NEXT

The keyboard

Your guarantees

The limits

What's new

If something goes wrong

To re-source Ctrl+5

The fakes and the truncated files: a shopping list.

Trash Ctrl+6

Duplicates and mistakes. Nothing is erased on its own.

Rekordbox Ctrl+7

Sync the filed library with Rekordbox.

USB drive Ctrl+8

Format and eject a drive for the players.

Settings Ctrl+9

Root folder, conversion, naming, Discogs, appearance.

Review

The main screen: one track at a time, you listen, then you decide. The file list is on the left, the open track in the center, the diagnostics on the right. The list filters by category (Lossless, MP3, Fake, Duplicates...) and by search, **Ctrl+F** goes straight there.

For each track you get the player, the verdict, a metadata sheet you can edit in place, Discogs identification and the full audio diagnostics. Sound comes before the verdict: you listen, then you call it.

SPACE listen **ENTER** convert **BKSP** set aside **UP/DOWN** navigate **I** identify **CTRL+Z** undo

- **Convert.** The file leaves for its destination, converted to MP3, WAV or AIFF as you choose, with a filename built from the tags. The Destination menu offers the tree of your library and your other folders.
- **Set aside.** The file goes to To re-source, with its reason; on a fake, the button reads **Re-source**. A duplicate is flagged as such, with the original track, and is sorted out in Duplicates.
- **Identify.** Sift queries Discogs, offers matches and writes the tags you keep into the file: artist, title, label, year, genres, cover art.

Batch mode

Tick tracks in the list: the center area sums up the selection (verdicts, formats, total length) and a single button files all of it. The **Selection** menu takes everything, takes nothing, takes one category only, or everything but the fakes; **Ctrl+A** and **Ctrl+Shift+A** do the same. Past a certain number of files, Sift recaps before it starts, then shows progress and a report.

Duplicates

Every duplicate in the library, those in the Review list as well as those already filed, in a single table: one group per track, one row per copy. Two copies form a group when they carry the same name, version included ("Original Mix" and "Extended Mix" stay two tracks), when they have the same content, or when their sound fingerprints agree. Each group says what it rests on: **Identical**, **Same sound** or **Same name**.

What Sift does

Install

Three words

The rail

SCREENS

Review 1

Duplicates 2

Log 3

Filed 4

To re-source 5

Trash 6

Rekordbox 7

USB drive 8

Settings 9

NEXT

The keyboard

Your guarantees

The limits

What's new

If something goes wrong

In each group the best copy is ticked **Keep**: GENUINE before FAKE, a whole copy before a truncated one, lossless before MP3. Tick others to keep them as well, or untick the one you don't want. What sets the copies apart is written in full, the rest fades; opening a copy plays it and compares it with the kept copy, fact by fact.

UP/DOWN previous / next copy **SPACE** listen **ENTER** keep only this one **BKSP** don't keep
CTRL+ENTER apply CTRL+Z undo

Nothing leaves until you click **Move to Trash**, which sums up the whole plan. Each copy goes to a trash on its own disk, without copying, and a single **Ctrl + Z** puts everything back. Copies Rekordbox plays stay kept, unless you untick the box in the confirmation. While Rekordbox is open, Sift can't see its latest imports: the confirmation says how many copies being moved couldn't be checked — quit Rekordbox and reopen Duplicates to check them. A **To check** group, two copies with the same name but different lengths, stays out of the plan until you decide it. A group that isn't one is removed with a right-click, "These aren't duplicates", and doesn't come back.

Log

The full history of what Sift has done, grouped by session and by day: tracks filed, moved to the Trash or set aside. Every line undoes in one click. A bulk filing that went to the wrong place comes back from here, even after restarting the application.

Filed

Your library as it sits on disk, in a Finder-style table: columns you customize and that are remembered, sorting, search, multiple selection with a summary panel. The cover art doubles as a play button. Right-click opens the file's location, re-runs the analysis, moves or sets aside. A bar shows the space each format takes.

To re-source

The fake or truncated files, each with its reason. Treat this list as a shopping list: these tracks are waiting to be bought again or found elsewhere. The **Return to queue** button puts a track back into the Review list if the verdict strikes you as too cautious.

Trash

The duplicates and the mistakes. Nothing is erased from the disk until you empty the Trash, and Sift asks for confirmation before doing it. The **Restore** button puts a file back in its place: a filed track returns to Filed, the others to the Review list.

Rekordbox

A single action syncs everything: **Sync selection** or **Sync all**. Sift compares your filed library with the Rekordbox one, groups what it proposes in four sections — **Files** (links to repair), **Metadata**, **Covers**, **Playlists** (duplicate entries) — and names each

What Sift does

Install

Three words

The rail

SCREENS

Review 1

Duplicates 2

Log 3

Filed 4

To re-source 5

Trash 6

Rekordbox 7

USB drive 8

Settings 9

NEXT

The keyboard

Your guarantees

The limits

What's new

If something goes wrong

item “Artist, Title”. Two ways to write: an XML file you import into Rekordbox, or writing straight into its database.

Rekordbox must be closed during a direct write. Sift backs up the database before touching it, verifies the backup, and refuses to act if the software is open.

USB drive

The left column lists the removable drives. For the drive you pick, you see the space taken by each format, its characteristics (mount point, format, capacity, free space, file count, model, device, health) and three actions: **Format...**, **Eject**, **Rescan drive**.

Formatting writes FAT32, the format the players read, even past the 32 GB Windows refuses; exFAT remains an option. It proceeds in blocks and shows the megabytes written.

Formatting erases everything on the drive. Sift asks twice, naming the volume, and refuses if the drive has changed in the meantime.

Settings

The categories on the left, the panel on the right. Every setting applies immediately, there is no Save button.

- **General:** the root folder of your library. It defines the filing tree, not the conversion.
- **Conversion:** what each conversion aims for, format by format — bitrate and sample rate for MP3, bit depth and sample rate for AIFF and WAV. An MP3 source is moved as is, never re-encoded.
- **Naming:** the filename template, built from the tags, with a live preview.
- **Identification:** your Discogs token.
- **Appearance:** the theme (Auto, Light or Dark) and the language (Auto, English or Français). Changing the language reloads the window.

`Ctrl` + `,` opens Settings from any screen.

What Sift does

Install

Three words

The rail

SCREENS

Review 1

Duplicates 2

Log 3

Filed 4

To re-source 5

Trash 6

Rekordbox 7

USB drive 8

Settings 9

NEXT

The keyboard

Your guarantees

The limits

What's new

If something goes wrong

The keyboard

Key	Where	Effect
Space	Review	play, pause
Enter	Review	convert the open track
Backspace or X	Review	set aside
↑ ↓	Review, tables	previous track, next track
I	Review	identify on Discogs
Ctrl + Z	anywhere	undo the last action
Ctrl + A / Ctrl + Shift + A	Review in Batch mode, tables	select everything, select nothing
Ctrl + F	screens with a search	go to the search
Ctrl + Enter	Duplicates	move the plan to the Trash, after confirmation
Ctrl + 1 to 9	anywhere	the matching screen, in rail order
Ctrl + B	anywhere	collapse or expand the rail
Ctrl + Alt + I	screens with an inspector	hide or show the inspector, the right-hand column (⌘ I on Mac)
Ctrl + ,	anywhere	Settings
Esc	anywhere	close the open menu or window

On Mac, ⌘ replaces Ctrl.

What Sift will never do without you

- **Delete a file.** Setting a track aside moves it. Only emptying the Trash erases, and it asks for confirmation.
- **Modify your download folders.** Sift reads them, it never writes them back.
- **Write into Rekordbox** without having first backed up and verified its database.
- **Make an action final.** Everything Sift does can be undone from the Log. On a large batch, the confirmation arms for a few moments so a double click cannot go through it.

What the detection does not see

No detector is perfect. Sift measures four things in the signal: the frequency where the spectrum stops, the density of the highs, the grid the encoder leaves in the samples, replayed for MP3 and for AAC, and the alignment of the codec's blocks. On its test set (8 verified purchases, 150 transcoded built from those purchases), it

What Sift does

Install

Three words

The rail

SCREENS

Review 1

Duplicates 2

Log 3

Filed 4

To re-source 5

Trash 6

Rekordbox 7

USB drive 8

Settings 9

NEXT

The keyboard

Your guarantees

The limits

What's new

If something goes wrong

accused no authentic file: that is the rule that comes first, better to let a fake through than to make you buy a good file again. Since v0.1.2, every MP3 in the test set is caught, whatever its bitrate, 320 and V0 included, and almost every AAC. Since v0.1.4, thanks to the block alignment, the Vorbis and WMA files in the test set, invisible until then, are caught too, ten out of ten each. What still gets through: some of the Opus transcodes, rated **TO CHECK** at best, and a few AAC 128.

In plain terms: a **FAKE** verdict is reliable. A **GENUINE** verdict means that nothing measurable contradicts the file, not that it is guaranteed authentic.

What's new

v0.1.6 — the USB drive.

- **Formatting as exFAT, or a FAT32 drive of 32 GB or less, finally works:** these formats failed before the Windows prompt even appeared. The volume name you choose is applied in exFAT too.
- **Formatting a blank drive takes a few seconds** instead of about forty.
- The format window's warnings move into ⓘ bubbles.

[The v0.1.6 release notes.](#)

v0.1.5 — a duplicates group whose copies are all truncated keeps its best copy, instead of offering to move everything to the Trash.

v0.1.4 — sorting duplicates, and Sift in English. This version installs by hand: the key that signs updates has changed, so a 0.1.3 installation refuses the automatic update. Your library and settings are kept.

- **A Duplicates screen:** every copy of the same track, compared, a “Keep” box per copy, a single move to the Trash and a single **Ctrl + Z** to undo it all.
- **Throwing away no longer copies:** each file goes to a trash on its own disk, instantly.
- **The interface in English,** to choose in Settings.
- **Review:** the original bitrate in the verdict, files under 320 kbps flagged, a spectrogram you can enlarge, switching releases without re-identifying.
- **Detection:** Vorbis and WMA files disguised as lossless are caught.

[The v0.1.4 release notes.](#)

v0.1.2 — the detection no longer lets bitrate fool it:

- **MP3s disguised as lossless are recognized whatever their bitrate,** 320 and V0 included: the probe replays the MP3 encoder and finds its grid in the samples. A lossless that cuts off between 20,000 and 20,750 Hz, the signature of a 320 MP3, turns TO CHECK instead of GENUINE.
- **AACs too,** including at 128 kbps: the probe looks at the long blocks with the window the encoder uses, and on the right bands.
- A track longer than 9 minutes is probed on its first 9 minutes instead of being skipped.

[The v0.1.2 release notes.](#)

v0.1.1 — first version published since 0.0.3. The essentials:

- **An interface redone screen by screen,** read against Finder, Music, Mail, Photos, Disk Utility and System Settings, then adapted to Windows habits. One bar, a sectioned rail carrying the sources (the Home screen is gone), a one-word

What Sift does

Install

Three words

The rail

SCREENS

Review 1

Duplicates 2

Log 3

Filed 4

To re-source 5

Trash 6

Rekordbox 7

USB drive 8

Settings 9

NEXT

The keyboard

Your guarantees

The limits

What's new

If something goes wrong

verdict, Batch mode and the Selection menu, Filed Finder-style, Log as a table, Rekordbox in a single sync, USB drive and Settings redrawn.

- **More reliable detection:** two more signals (density of the highs, the codec's trace in the samples), the verdict replayed at startup when the engine changes, without a new analysis.
- **USB drive:** FAT32 written in blocks, progress shown in megabytes, external SSDs ejected.
- **Speed:** analysis reports twenty times smaller, incremental deduplication.
- **Intel Mac:** an installer, alongside Apple silicon and Windows.

The detail is in [the release notes](#).

If something goes wrong

Errors appear in the application with their cause. If a file refuses to analyze, its message stays visible on its row. An available update offers itself at startup.

To report a problem: github.com/c0remusic/sift/issues. Give the version, your machine, and what you expected.

Sift v0.1.6, Windows and macOS.